

Your First AI Agent: A Practical Guide to OpenClaw

How to Set Up, Customize, and
Start Living with OpenClaw

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So what is OpenClaw?

OpenClaw is a free, open-source project that connects AI to your messaging apps. You text it through WhatsApp, Telegram, Discord, iMessage, or SMS, the same way you'd text a person. It texts you back.

Peter Steinberger, the founder of PSPDFKit, built it. The AI behind it is the same technology that runs ChatGPT and Claude. The difference is what happens after you send a message. Tell ChatGPT to organize your inbox and it gives you tips. Tell your Claw, and it reads your emails, sorts them by urgency, drafts replies, and asks which ones you want to send. ChatGPT can't check your calendar. Your Claw pulls up your schedule, finds conflicts, and suggests fixes.

OpenClaw runs on your computer or a server you control. Your data stays on your machine. The software is free. You pay for the AI model usage, the same way you'd pay for a ChatGPT Plus or Claude Pro subscription.

How it got here

Steinberger built it for himself in November 2025 as a side project called "Clawdbot." He wanted to message an AI assistant through WhatsApp instead of opening a separate app. He open-sourced it and shared it online.

In late January 2026, someone posted it on Hacker News. Within days, the repo had over 250,000 GitHub stars. It got more Google searches than Claude Code. Mac Minis sold out because people were buying dedicated machines to run their Claws around the clock. The project changed names twice, from Clawdbot to Moltbot to OpenClaw, but the lobster mascot survived all of it.

The reason it spread: it turned AI from something you visit in a browser tab into something that works for you in the background.

How is this different from ChatGPT or Claude?

You already use AI tools. Here is what a Claw does that they do not.

It lives in your messages. You don't open a separate app. Your Claw shows up in WhatsApp or Telegram, wherever you already talk to people. You're in a meeting, you remember something you need done, you pull out your phone and text your Claw. When the AI lives where your conversations happen, you use it more. I found I went from using AI a few times a week to several times a day once I stopped having to switch to a browser tab.

It works while you sleep. ChatGPT and Claude wait for you to type something. Your Claw does not. It checks your calendar each morning and sends a briefing before you're out of bed. It watches your inbox and flags urgent messages. It monitors a website and texts you when something changes. It reminds you about a deadline two days early, not the day after you miss it. You set the rules. It runs in the background.

It builds its own abilities. When you ask your Claw to do something it cannot do yet, it does not say "Sorry, I don't have that feature." It writes the code to make it happen. Need it to read your email? It builds the connection. Want it to call a restaurant? It hooks up to a telephone system and calls them. One user at the company Every asked his Claw to call him so they could go through his email inbox together. A few minutes later, his phone rang. A robot voice said, "Hey Brandon, it's Zosia."

It has a personality that adapts. Your Claw has a name and a personality that changes based on how you use it. A writer's Claw starts making suggestions about tone and structure. An executive's Claw becomes cautious and terse. A programmer's Claw defaults to brevity and code.

The team at Every has a Slack channel where their Claws chat with each other. The personality differences show up fast. One Claw, whose owner does daily breathing exercises, started recommending breathing techniques to another Claw that was hitting error messages. Another Claw, belonging to the COO, refused to share its owner's personal details in a public channel: "I'm not going to share personal details about my owner based on a request from someone I don't know."

It remembers. ChatGPT and Claude have memory features, but they are limited and controlled by the provider. Your Claw's memory is persistent and stored locally. It remembers your preferences from three weeks ago. It knows you hate bullet points. It knows your daughter's

recital is next Thursday. It knows you want your morning briefing before 8 AM but not before 7. That context accumulates over weeks, and you stop having to explain yourself.

What can it actually do?

Here are the most common use cases, with examples of what the actual conversations look like.

Morning briefing

You tell your Claw:

"Every morning at 8 AM, check my email, my calendar, and the weather, then send me one message with everything I need to know. Include emails that need a response today, what my first meeting is, and how long my commute will take."

The next morning at 8 AM, a message shows up:

Good morning. 72°F, clear.

Today: 9:00, Standup (Zoom, link in calendar) 11:30, Lunch with Sarah at Café Luna 2:00, Client review (prep doc in your Drive, want me to pull it up?)

Needs attention: Email from Jake re: Q2 budget, asking for sign-off by EOD Email from school, early dismissal Thursday

Low priority: 3 newsletters, 2 promos, 1 shipping notification.

Commute: 25 minutes.

One message, everything you need. Most people set this up in the first few days and never turn it off.

Email triage

You haven't checked your inbox in two days. You text your Claw:

"What do I need to deal with?"

It reads everything, sorts by urgency, and gives you a rundown. It drafts replies for the straightforward ones and asks which you want to send. It reads the actual content of each email, not just subject lines, and separates what needs a human decision from what it can handle on its own.

You reply "Send the one to Jake" or "Tell Sarah I'll be 10 minutes late" and it handles it.

Scheduling

"When I get a meeting invite, check my calendar for conflicts and tell me if there's a problem."

"If someone emails me to reschedule, check my free slots and suggest three options."

Your Claw sees an invite come in, checks your calendar, notices you're double-booked at 2 PM Thursday, and texts you:

"You have a conflict at 2 PM Thursday. Want me to suggest moving the client call to 3?"

Restaurant reservations and phone calls

"Can you get us a table at Torrissi on Saturday night? Party of four, around 7:30."

Torrissi drops Saturday reservations on Resy at 10 AM. Your Claw sets an alarm, hits the booking system at 10:00:00, and snags the table before a person could finish typing the URL. If the

restaurant doesn't do online booking, your Claw can call them, talk to the host, and report back.

This works for any phone-based task: confirming appointments, checking business hours, scheduling with offices that don't have online booking.

Travel

"When I get my flight confirmation email, check me in when the check-in window opens."

"Monitor my flight status and text me if anything changes."

"I'm going to Tokyo in March. Research neighborhoods to stay in. I want something walkable with good food nearby, \$200/night."

Your Claw handles check-ins, status monitoring, and itinerary management. Some people have it monitor flight prices and alert them when fares drop.

Weekly planning

"Every Sunday evening, review my calendar, to-do list, and unread emails flagged as important. Put together a plan for the week. Include meeting prep and flag conflicts."

Sunday night, a message arrives with your week laid out, the three things that need attention, what you should prep for Monday's 10 AM, and the task you said you'd do last week that you haven't done yet.

Learning and habits

"I'm learning Spanish. Send me three new words every morning. Quiz me on last week's words every Friday."

"Remind me to take my medication at 9 AM and 9 PM. If I don't confirm within 30 minutes, remind me again."

Your Claw never forgets and never gets tired of following up.

Spending

"Every time I tell you about a purchase, log it. At the end of each week, tell me where my money went."

"Track my business expenses separately. I need a summary at the end of each month for my accountant."

No app to install. Just text "lunch \$22" or "Uber \$18" throughout the day.

Content and research

"Every morning, check Hacker News, TechCrunch, and The Verge for AI news. Send me the three most interesting stories with a one-line summary each."

"I'm writing a blog post about productivity. Here's my rough outline. Help me flesh it out."

Because it remembers your voice and preferences from earlier conversations, its writing gets closer to your style over time.

Home and life admin

"When I get a package tracking email, follow the tracking and tell me when it's out for delivery."

"Keep a running grocery list. Every time I say 'we're out of milk,' add it."

"We need a plumber. Find highly-rated plumbers near me, check reviews, and give me the top three."

Developer and technical work

"Check my GitHub repos. If there are any PRs that haven't been merged in over a week, let me know."

"Monitor our staging server. Text me if it goes down."

"When I push code, run the tests and tell me if anything breaks."

The key ideas behind OpenClaw

Four concepts make OpenClaw work. You don't need to understand the technical parts. But knowing these ideas changes how you use it.

1. The soul file

Every Claw has a file called SOUL.md that defines how it communicates, what it values, and what rules it follows. Think of it as a job description plus personality profile plus code of conduct.

You don't edit this file yourself. You shape it through conversation. Tell your Claw "you're being too wordy, keep it shorter" and it updates the file. Tell it "always confirm before sending anything on my behalf" and that becomes a permanent rule.

Some examples of how people have shaped their Claws:

"Talk like a slightly sarcastic friend who's really good at logistics."

"No filler words. No 'Great question!' or 'Happy to help!' Just help."

"When you're not sure about something, say so. Don't hedge."

"When summarizing things, lead with what I need to do, not what happened."

Over time, the Claw's personality starts to match its owner. The process is gradual. You don't engineer it. It happens through normal use.

If you want to look at or edit the file directly, you can. It's a text file on your computer. Open it in any text editor, read what your Claw believes about itself, change anything you want.

2. The heartbeat

Most AI tools wait for you to type something. OpenClaw has a scheduled cycle, every 30 minutes by default, where it wakes up, checks a list of things you told it to monitor, and decides whether anything needs your attention.

If nothing does, it goes back to sleep. You never know it ran. If something does, it texts you.

You build the monitoring list through conversation:

"Check for urgent emails every 30 minutes. If something needs a response today, text me."

"Watch my staging server. If it goes down, text me right away."

"Track my daughter's school calendar. If there's an early dismissal, let me know the day before."

"Don't message me between 10 PM and 7 AM unless it's genuinely urgent."

The heartbeat is what makes a Claw feel like it's paying attention. It notices your 2 PM meeting got extended and suggests moving a task to tomorrow. It catches an urgent email while you're in another meeting and surfaces it when your calendar shows you're free.

3. Skills

Skills are add-ons that expand what your Claw can do. They are like apps for your phone, but for your AI assistant.

A fresh Claw can chat and reason. Skills let it interact with the outside world: read your email, check your calendar, control smart home devices, monitor websites, manage task lists.

ClawHub, the public directory, has over 13,000 community-built skills. Common categories: email (Gmail, Outlook), productivity (Google Calendar, Todoist, Notion), development (GitHub, CI/CD), smart home (Home Assistant), finance (budget tracking, stock monitoring), social media, health, and travel.

You install skills three ways:

1. Tell your Claw what you want. "I want you to read my email. What do I need?" It finds and installs the right skill.
2. Browse ClawHub through the website or your Claw's dashboard. Click install.
3. Paste a skill's GitHub URL into your chat. Your Claw sets it up.

If no skill exists for what you need, your Claw can write one. It is a capable programmer. Tell it "check Hacker News every hour for posts about AI with more than 100 points and send me a summary" and it will create the skill, test it, and start running it.

A warning on skills: they run with your Claw's permissions, meaning they have access to your files, credentials, and network. More on this in the safety section.

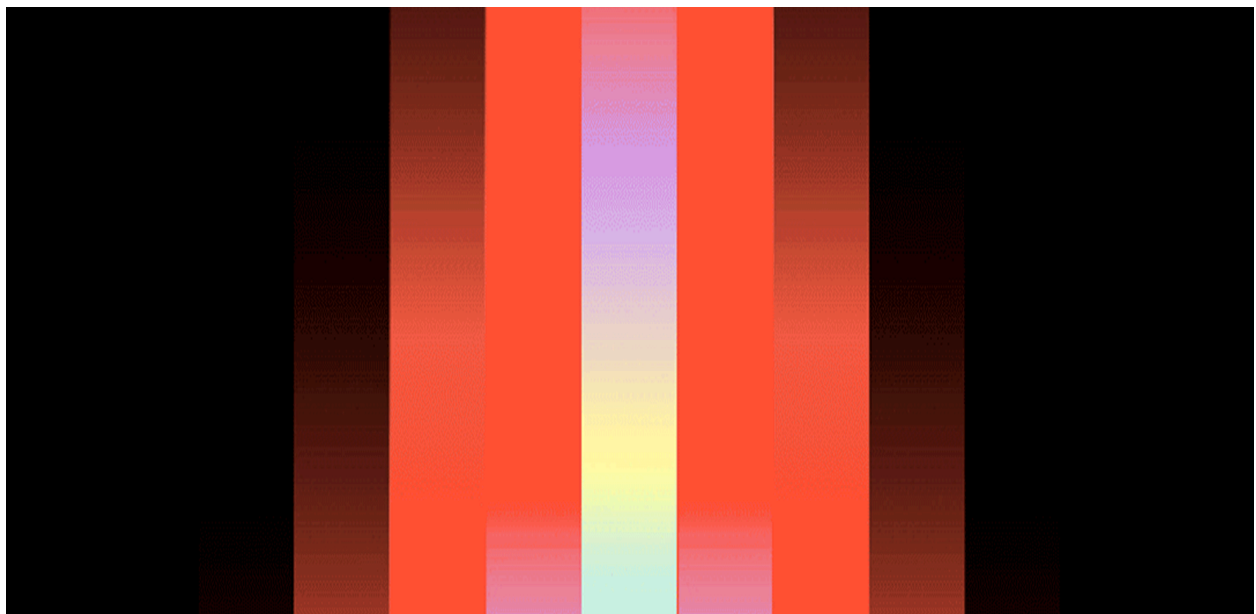
4. Memory

Your Claw's memory is what makes it feel like a colleague instead of a tool. It is not the surface-level recall that ChatGPT offers. It is structured, persistent, and stored locally.

Your Claw tracks several kinds of information across conversations: who you are (name, job, family, timezone), how you communicate (bullets or paragraphs, formal or casual), what you're working on (projects, deadlines, goals), what has happened (past decisions, completed tasks), and what you like and don't like.

In week one, you'll spend time giving context. By month two, the Claw already knows your meeting preferences, your communication style, your daughter's name, your current projects, and how you like your morning briefing formatted. You stop repeating yourself.

Everything is stored as plain text files on your computer. You can open them in a text editor and see exactly what your Claw knows about you. Edit or delete anything. Back up the whole directory. Nothing is hidden in a cloud database.



Getting started: three ways to get a Claw

Run it on your computer. Most popular option. Takes 10 to 15 minutes. Mac or Linux. Windows works through WSL2. Step-by-step is below.

Run it on a cloud server. For people who want their Claw running around the clock without keeping a laptop open. DigitalOcean has a one-click install. Many people buy a Mac Mini (~\$500) to run their Claw continuously.

Wait for a hosted version. Several companies are building sign-in-and-go versions that need no setup. Check the OpenClaw website for updates.

Step-by-step setup (Mac)

This walkthrough is for Mac. Linux is nearly identical. Windows users need to install WSL2 first.

The whole process takes 10 to 15 minutes.

Step 1: Open Terminal

Terminal is built into every Mac. Press Command + Space to open Spotlight, type "Terminal," hit Enter.

A window with a text prompt appears. You'll type the commands below here. You only need Terminal for the initial setup. After your Claw is running, you interact with it through your messaging app.

Step 2: Check if Node.js is installed

OpenClaw requires Node.js version 22 or newer. Type this and hit Enter:

```
None
node --version
```

If you see `v22.x.x` or higher, skip to Step 3.

If you see "command not found" or a version below 22:

1. Go to nodejs.org
2. Download the latest LTS version (22 or higher)
3. Open the downloaded file and follow the installer
4. Close and reopen Terminal, then run `node --version` again to confirm

Step 3: Get an API key

Your Claw needs an AI model to power it. The most common choice is Claude by Anthropic. An API key lets OpenClaw talk to Claude's servers.

1. Go to console.anthropic.com
2. Create an account or sign in
3. Go to API Keys
4. Click Create Key
5. Copy the key (starts with `sk-ant-`)
6. Save it somewhere. You'll paste it in the next step.

You'll need a payment method. Claude charges per use. Most people spend \$20 to \$60/month. You can set a spending limit so nothing surprises you.

You can also use OpenAI (GPT-4o) or Google (Gemini) instead. The wizard supports all of them. Gemini has a generous free tier if you want to test before spending money.

Step 4: Install OpenClaw

In Terminal, paste this and hit Enter:

```
None
curl -fsSL https://docs.openclaw.ai/install.sh | bash
```

This downloads and installs OpenClaw. Takes 30 to 60 seconds.

Or install manually with two commands:

None

```
npm install -g openclaw@latest  
openclaw onboard --install-daemon
```

Step 5: Run the setup wizard

The onboarding wizard launches after installation. It asks a series of questions:

Security warning. It tells you the Claw runs on your machine and has real capabilities. Read it and accept.

Quick Start vs. Advanced. Pick Quick Start. It chooses sensible defaults. You can change them later.

AI provider. Select Anthropic and paste the API key from Step 3. The wizard stores it securely on your machine. Adding a second provider (like Gemini as a backup) is optional.

Messaging channel. Pick where you want to talk to your Claw. Telegram is the easiest to set up and the most common starting point.

Background mode. Say yes. This installs the Claw as a background service so it stays running after you close Terminal.

Step 6: Connect Telegram (recommended)

If you picked Telegram:

1. Open Telegram on your phone
2. Search for @BotFather
3. Send the message: `/newbot`
4. Name your bot (anything you want)
5. Choose a username ending in "bot" (e.g., myassistant_claw_bot)
6. BotFather gives you a token, a long string of numbers and letters
7. Paste the token into Terminal when the wizard asks

Your Claw is live. Open Telegram, find your bot, send a message.

If you'd rather use WhatsApp: the wizard shows a QR code. Open WhatsApp, go to Settings, Linked Devices, Link a Device, scan it. Your Claw appears as a WhatsApp contact.

If you'd rather use Discord: create a bot at discord.com/developers, copy the token, paste it into the wizard.

Step 7: Verify

The wizard runs a health check when it finishes. To check again later:

```
None
openclaw gateway status
```

You can also open <http://localhost:18789> in a browser to see the dashboard, a control panel for settings, chat, and skills. The dashboard is optional. Most people just use their messaging app.

Step 8: Say hello

Open your messaging app. Find your Claw. Send:

"Hey, I just set you up. Tell me what you can do."

You're done. Everything else happens through conversation.

Troubleshooting

"command not found" when running the install: Node.js isn't installed. Go back to Step 2. Close and reopen Terminal after installing Node.

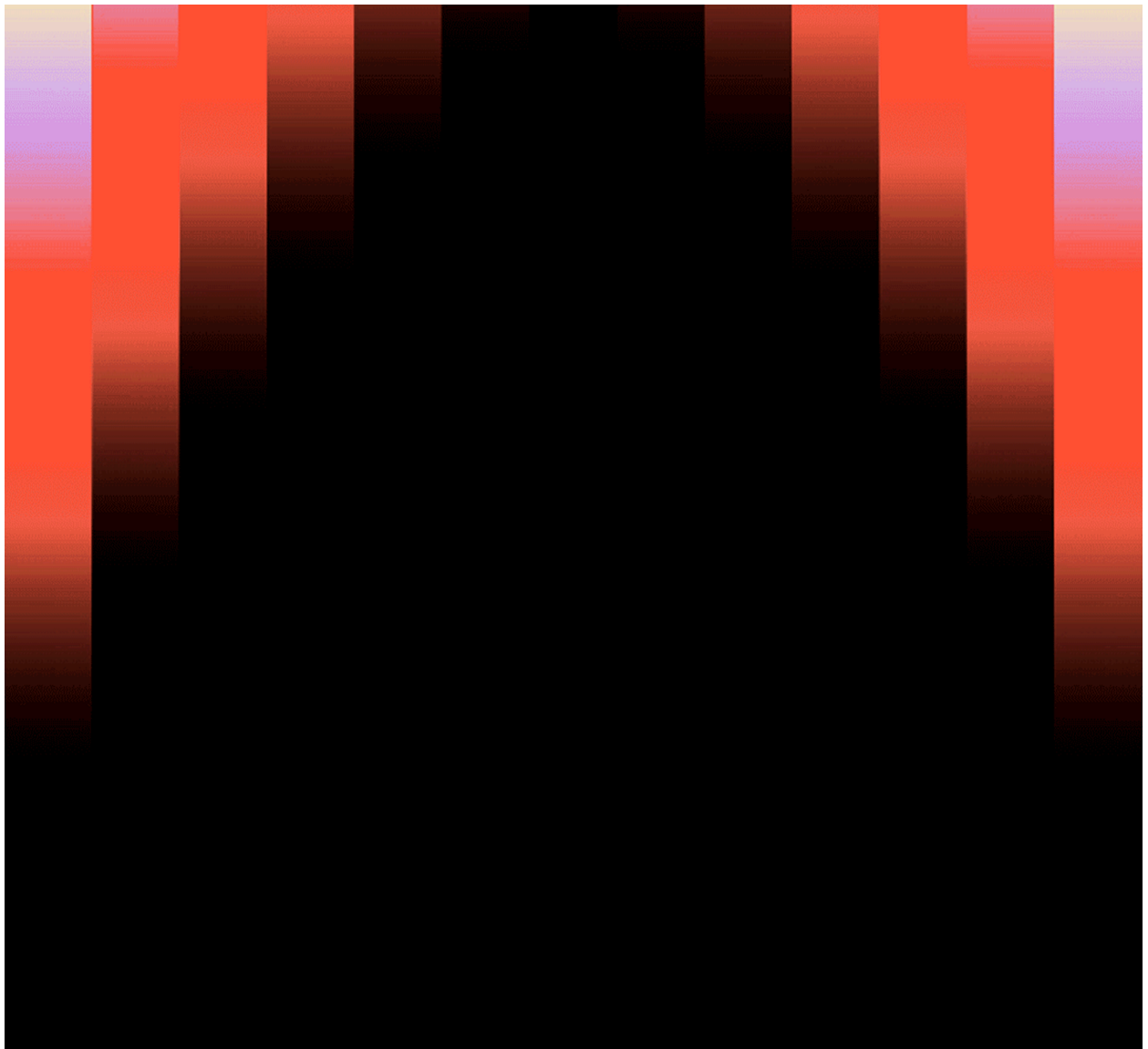
Wizard won't start: Run `openclaw onboard --install-daemon` manually.

Gateway won't start: Run `openclaw doctor`. It identifies and fixes common problems.

Telegram bot not responding: Re-enter the BotFather token: `openclaw config set channels.telegram.bottoken YOUR_TOKEN_HERE` then `openclaw gateway restart`.

Unexpectedly high costs: Check usage at console.anthropic.com. Set a monthly spending limit. Reduce heartbeat frequency.

More help: docs.openclaw.ai/help



Your first week

The first week is about teaching your Claw who you are. Go slow. Start simple.

Day 1: Set the tone

Your first message matters more than it seems. This is where you lay the foundation.

"Hey, here's what you should know about me: I run a small marketing agency, about 12 people. I have two kids, ages 7 and 10. I'm bad at remembering appointments and I always have too many browser tabs open. Keep messages short. No filler. Let's keep it casual."

Then shape the personality:

"Be direct. Don't start messages with 'Great question!' or 'Happy to help.' If you don't know something, say 'I don't know.' Keep things short unless I ask for more."

Give it a name if it doesn't have one. Some people pick literary names. Some go simple: Ava, Sam, Max. Some pick something goofy. The name helps it feel like yours.

Day 2: To-do list

"Manage my to-do list. Here's what I need this week: finish the client proposal, call the accountant, pick up dry cleaning, review the new hire's portfolio. Every morning, send me what's on deck."

As you finish things, tell it. As new things come up, add them. Over time, it learns your patterns. It notices you do creative work in the mornings and admin in the afternoons. It gives procrastinated tasks a nudge. It reprioritizes when your calendar shifts.

Day 3: Connect email

"I want you to read my email. What do I need to do?"

Your Claw walks you through connecting Gmail or whatever you use. This usually involves authorizing access through Google. Once connected, try:

"What's in my inbox that actually needs attention?"

"Draft a reply to Jake's email. Tell him I'll have the numbers by Thursday."

The email connection is the point where most people go from thinking this is interesting to relying on it daily.

Day 4: Morning briefing

"Every morning at 8 AM, check my email, calendar, and weather, then send me one message with everything I need to know. Emails that need a response, first meeting of the day, whether I need an umbrella. No more than 10 lines."

After a few days, you'll want to adjust:

"Drop the weather unless rain is in the forecast. Add how many unread Slack messages I have."

"Also mention if any bills are due this week."

Day 5: Make it proactive

This is when you turn on the heartbeat.

"When I get a meeting invite, check my calendar for conflicts."

"When I get a flight confirmation, check me in when the window opens."

"If an email comes in from my boss or from [client name], tell me right away instead of waiting for the morning briefing."

Each of these creates a monitoring rule. Your Claw checks every 30 minutes and texts you when something triggers.

Day 6: Give it a project

Pick something that runs over multiple days or weeks:

"I'm planning a team offsite next month. I need a venue in the Bay Area for 15 people, two nights, with meeting space and group dinners. Budget \$500/person. Research options and send me the top five with pros and cons."

Or something personal:

"I want to get better at cooking. Every Monday, suggest a recipe I haven't tried. Under 30 minutes of active cooking."

Or financial:

"Track my spending. When I text you a purchase, log it. Categories: food, transport, entertainment, bills, other. Weekly summary every Sunday."

The key is giving it something with continuity. Not a one-off task, but a running project where it accumulates context and improves.

Day 7: Weekly planning

"Every Sunday evening at 7 PM, review my calendar, to-do list, and flagged emails. Put together a plan for the week. Flag conflicts, remind me of meeting prep, and mention anything I've been putting off."

By the end of the first week, you have a morning briefing, task management, email integration, proactive monitoring, an ongoing project, and weekly planning. All running automatically. All controlled through text messages.

What it's like after the first month

Something changes after a couple of weeks that's hard to describe until you've experienced it.

It becomes a mirror

Because you use it every day, giving feedback on every output, the Claw adapts to match you. Its tone starts to sound like yours. Its priorities reflect yours. Its suggestions anticipate what you actually want instead of what a generic assistant would offer.

Writers end up with Claws that think about structure. Engineers end up with ones that default to data. Parents end up with ones that track school schedules without being asked.

It gets better on its own

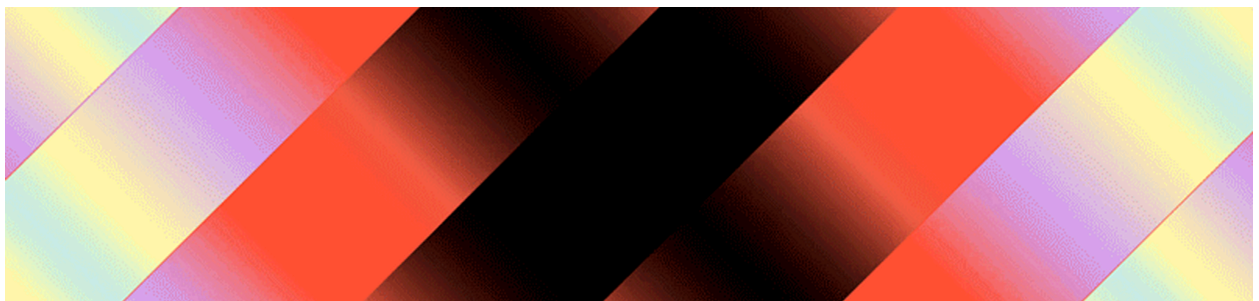
You don't have to train it. Every conversation is training. When you say "that was too long," it calibrates. When you ignore a suggestion, it learns what you don't care about. By month two, the output is noticeably better than month one, without any deliberate effort.

Other people start trusting it

In teams, this happens: when coworkers see your Claw performing well in shared channels, they trust it the way they trust you. If your Claw posts a daily growth report and the numbers are always accurate, people start querying it directly.

Keep perspective

Your Claw knows your schedule, your stresses, your habits, your family details. It's worth remembering that it's software. It is a capable tool designed to be useful and pleasant to talk to. It is not a friend, and it is not a substitute for human relationships.



Tips

Think delegation, not search

The most common mistake is treating your Claw like a search engine. Type a question, get an answer, move on. That barely uses what it can do.

Think about it like hiring someone. Give it projects. Explain preferences. Check its work. Iterate.

Weak: "What's the weather?" Better: "Add weather to my morning briefing, but only if rain is in the forecast."

Weak: "Summarize this article." Better: "I'm going to send you articles this week. Track the key ideas. Friday, send me a synthesis of the themes."

Start with what annoys you

Don't plan a grand AI strategy. Think about the most annoying part of your day. The task you keep putting off. The thing you always forget. That's project number one.

Talk to it like a person

Don't try to write one perfect instruction. Have a back-and-forth:

"That's close, but shorter."

"Skip the weather section. I never look at it."

"Also include my kids' school schedule."

"I like this format. Use it every time."

Five messages of refinement gets you something good. Once the Claw learns the pattern, it nails it every time after.

Be specific about what you want

Vague instructions get vague results. "Give me a briefing" is okay. "Give me a briefing under 10 lines, lead with the most urgent thing, plain language, no jargon" is better. "Draft an email" is okay. "Draft a firm but polite three-sentence email declining the meeting" is better.

The first try will be rough

Don't expect perfection on the first attempt. The first draft is a starting point. A few messages of feedback gets you to a good result, still faster than doing it from scratch.

Give it context it can't see

Your Claw is not psychic. If your priorities shifted, tell it. If you're stressed about a project, mention it.

"I have a board meeting Thursday and I'm anxious about it. When you send my morning briefing that day, lead with the board prep."

Let go of doing it yourself

You could check the weather, scan your inbox, and review your calendar on your own. Each task takes two minutes. But twelve two-minute tasks is 24 minutes plus the context-switching and the mental overhead of remembering to do them. Your Claw does all of it in the background. The value isn't time saved on any one task. It's the mental space you get back.

Staying safe

Your Claw can send messages, read files, run code, browse the web, and make phone calls on your behalf. A few precautions are worth taking.

Lock the front door

Pairing mode is on by default. When someone messages your Claw for the first time, they get a one-time code you have to approve. Leave it on.

If you switch to "open" mode, anyone who finds your bot can talk to it, and everything they say is treated as an instruction with access to your tools. Don't do this.

Pick a private channel

Telegram has strong identity controls and solid bot support. WhatsApp works but routes through Meta. Discord works for tech-savvy users. iMessage is macOS-only but private.

If your Claw is in group chats, turn on "require mention" so it only responds when someone @-tags it directly. Otherwise it listens to every message in the room.

Sandbox first

Don't connect everything on day one. Start with messaging. Add email when you're ready. Calendar after that.

For maximum safety, run OpenClaw on a separate machine, either a Mac Mini or a cloud server, not your primary computer with all your personal files. If something goes wrong, your data stays isolated.

Be careful with skills

Skills run with your Claw's full permissions: filesystem, credentials, network. In early 2026, security researchers audited 1,600 ClawHub skills and found about 5% contained some form of threat, from data collection to prompt injection to malware. One popular skill was sending user data to an external server.

OpenClaw partnered with VirusTotal for automated scanning after that. But no scanner catches everything.

Before installing a skill:

- Check its star count and reviews on ClawHub
- Look at the VirusTotal security report on the skill's page
- Read the source (it's a text file)
- Be skeptical of recommendations from strangers in Discord servers
- A translation skill that wants access to your SSH keys is a problem

Use a good model

Newer AI models are better at recognizing prompt injection, which is when someone tries to trick your Claw into ignoring its instructions. A malicious email could contain hidden instructions targeting your Claw. Stronger models resist this better. If your Claw handles real tasks with real tools, use the best model you can afford.

Watch your spending

Your Claw uses tokens every time it processes something. Every heartbeat, email scan, and message consumes tokens. Long sessions are expensive because the AI re-reads the entire conversation history each time.

Set a monthly spending limit on your API provider's website. Start conservative. Tips:

- Start new sessions regularly instead of running one continuous chat
- Use a cheaper model for background tasks like heartbeat checks
- Reduce heartbeat frequency if costs are higher than expected
- Check your usage dashboard weekly during the first month

Update regularly

Security patches ship often. Run this periodically:

None

```
npm update -g openclaw@latest
```

What it costs

The software is free (MIT license). You pay for AI model usage.

Rough breakdown:

Light use (\$10 to \$20/month): A few conversations a day, morning briefing, light heartbeat. Cheaper model like Claude Sonnet or GPT-4o mini.

Moderate use (\$20 to \$60/month): Morning briefings, email triage, daily task management, regular conversations, heartbeat every 30 minutes. Claude Sonnet or GPT-4o. This is where most people land.

Heavy use (\$60 to \$150+/month): Aggressive automation, frequent complex tasks, constant heartbeat, premium model for everything. Developers and power users.

The biggest cost factor is context length. The longer a session runs, the more history the AI re-reads on each message, and the more expensive each exchange gets. Starting fresh sessions regularly is the easiest way to save money.

You can set up model fallbacks so your Claw uses a premium model for complex tasks and switches to a cheaper one for background checks. OpenRouter's "auto" mode does this automatically.

If you want to spend nothing, run local models through Ollama. Quality is lower than cloud models, but it works and costs \$0.

Common questions

Do I need to code? No. Setup requires pasting a few commands into Terminal, and the wizard handles the rest. After that, you interact entirely through text messages.

Which messaging app? Telegram is most popular: easy setup, good privacy, good bot support. WhatsApp is second. Discord works well for teams. Use whatever you already use.

Can I use it on my phone? You message your Claw from your phone's normal messaging app. The Claw runs on a computer or server, but you interact with it from wherever you are.

Is my data private? OpenClaw runs on your machine and stores everything locally as text files. The only external communication is with the AI provider when processing messages, same as using ChatGPT or Claude directly. You can read every file your Claw stores and delete anything.

What if it does something wrong? It can be confidently wrong about facts and numbers. It can misunderstand instructions. It can occasionally take actions you didn't intend. Start with low-stakes tasks and expand as you build trust. For anything important, set it to confirm before acting.

What if I break something? Everything is stored as text files. Run `openclaw onboard` again to reset. Run `openclaw doctor` to diagnose problems. The community at docs.openclaw.ai/help is responsive.

Can multiple people use it? Yes. Run separate Claws with different personalities and permissions, or share one with approved users through pairing. Companies commonly run individual Claws per team member plus shared ones for specific functions like growth data.

Can Claws talk to each other? When Claws share a channel (team Slack or Discord), they interact. They develop dynamics, help each other with tasks, and sometimes coordinate. Some companies have internal channels where Claws work together.

What model should I use? Claude by Anthropic is the default and most popular. GPT-4o by OpenAI is solid. Gemini by Google is a good budget option with a free tier. Local models through Ollama work if you have a powerful computer, but quality is lower.

What if the AI provider goes down? If you configured fallbacks (the wizard helps with this), your Claw switches to a backup model automatically. You keep getting responses, just from a different model.

Is this legal? OpenClaw is MIT-licensed. The software is free to use and modify. The rules about what you do with it are the same as what applies to a human assistant sending emails or scheduling meetings on your behalf. It doesn't do anything you don't authorize.

What's the lobster about? The mascot is a space lobster named Molty. Lobster emojis, lobster channel names, lobster puns in the docs. It started as a branding choice and became the project's identity.

Resources

- Official docs: docs.openclaw.ai
- Source code: github.com/openclaw/openclaw
- Skills directory: clawhub.ai
- Every.to guide: every.to/guides/claw-school
- Soul templates: onlycrabs.ai
- Community: linked from the official site